

probably the home the kids all liked to hang out at, which was a source of pride for you and your spouse. When Junior chose the local community college because it was cheaper, and you let him come and go like the young adult he was, there were no questions and no rules. When he graduated and went looking for his own apartment, he had a hard time finding one with speakers by the pool and stainless-steel appliances. It just wasn't the same. So he gave up the search.

That was two years ago, and he's been comfortably ensconced in his—correction, I mean *your*—basement ever since. Meanwhile, you're still cooking and cleaning for a grown man. The truth is, your child is no longer a child, but an adult spoiled by the middle-class luxuries to which he (or she) has grown accustomed but has never earned.

First, congratulations. You raised a happy child. But never encouraging your kid to leave home, to find his or her own footing, is a dangerous thing. *You have to kick the kid out.* Plain and simple. You may think I'm being dramatic about this, but take a look at the statistics: According to *Forbes*, 15.8 million adult children were living with their parents at the end of 2012. A lot of those parents couldn't sell their houses when they wanted and needed to because their adult children were still hanging around, preventing them from liquidating the one asset they had set aside for a comfortable retirement. Timing is everything in the last few years leading to retirement; selling houses, downsizing, and transferring investments are tricky business. In other words, adult children living at home are interfering with crucial life and financial decisions parents have to make.

This is where it gets hard-core. But it's imperative that you understand you are helping your son or daughter in the long run. Your adult child needs to achieve self-sufficiency. Without that basic skill, I'm sorry, but your kid is not going to function well in the real world.

By letting your grown children overstay their welcome, you're teaching them they can quit jobs just because they feel like it. You're teaching them that other people will pick up after them, clean for them, cook for them, and cushion all their falls. You're teaching them that they're entitled to all the amenities without all the work. You're teaching them that if they pout, moan, or ignore a directive from you, it will go away. You're teaching them that life is too hard for them to